Into the Woods

Workshop Report: Exploring Local Perspectives on Nature Park Experiences

Workshop date: October 27, 2026
Location: Kuldīga, Latvia
Workshop duration: 2 hours
Prepared for: LVM Nature Park Team
Facilitation team: Khushboo, Anna, Amber, Fahad, Shruti
Participants: 12 teenagers (ages 16-18), 4 adults

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1. Workshop Goal

Background and Purpose

The *Into the Woods* workshop was designed to explore how local young people perceive natural spaces and co-create an ideal nature park experience with them.Through a series of playful, participatory activities, the workshop encouraged participants to share their personal associations with forests, imagine their ideal nature park, and collaboratively design experiences that would make a park worth visiting.

The workshop also brought together two distinct perspectives: local teenagers, representing a potential younger visitor group, and adults - creating a broader picture on how to breach the gap of two age groups within the park.

Workshop Objectives

Goal 1: Identify what locals want to see in natural spaces and parks.

Explore the experiences, activities, and social factors that make nature parks attractive, particularly to younger audiences.

Goal 2: Uncover what locals value in leisure and nature experiences.

Understand what participants prioritize when imagining an ideal nature park and creating memorable experiences.

Intended Outcomes

- Identify recurring themes in how participants imagine and value nature parks.
- Explore differences between teenager and adult perspectives.
- Generate creative concepts that may inspire future nature park experiences.
- Gather preliminary insights that can inform the next stage of research and service design.

2. Methodological Approach

Workshop Format

The workshop followed an exploratory service design approach. The team used creative exercises to encourage participants to express their preferences through storytelling, visual creation, discussion, and collaborative decision-making.

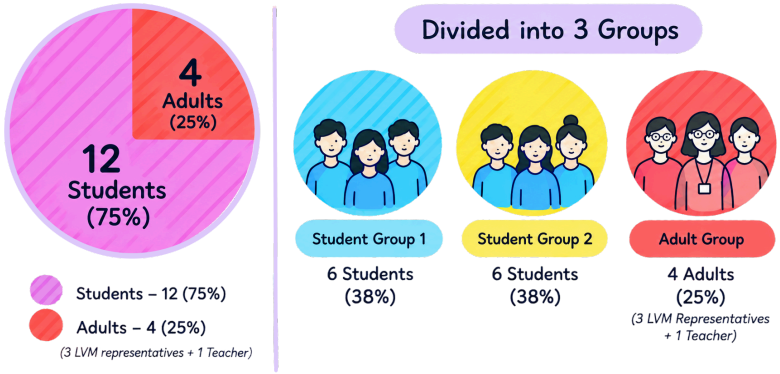
The activities moved from associations and warm-ups toward group ideation, collaborative prototyping, and reflection.

The methodology was designed to create an approachable environment for young participants while generating qualitative insights relevant to the LVM project.

2.1 Participants

The workshop included 14 participants:

- 12 local teenagers, aged 16 - 18.
- 4 adults.



Participants worked in three small groups (two teenager groups and one adult group made up of the teacher and adults), enabling the facilitation team to observe differences in perspectives and approaches.

The participation of adults provided an additional point of comparison between young potential visitors and professionals familiar with nature park operations.

2.2 Tasks and Methods Used

Activity 1: Forest Bingo

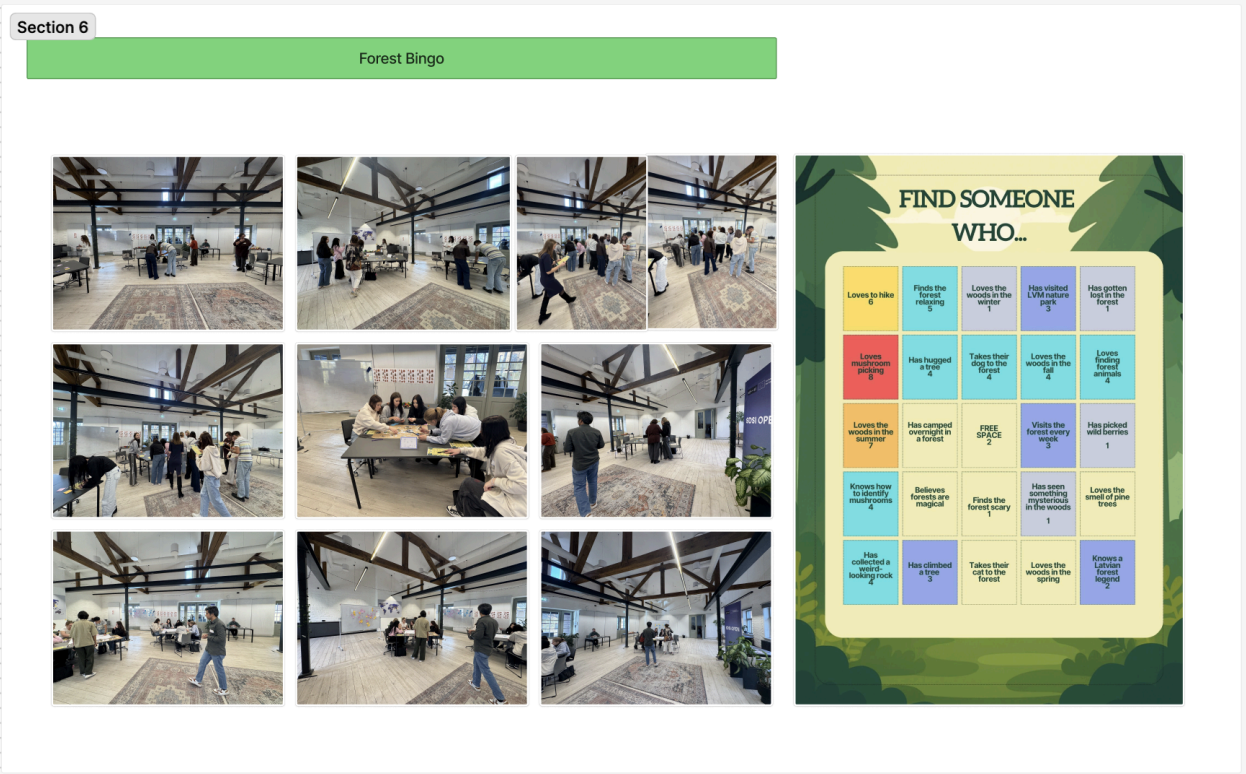
Method: Gamified icebreaker

Participants completed a forest-themed bingo exercise designed to introduce the topic and encourage interaction.

Purpose:

- Establish a comfortable and playful atmosphere.
- Encourage participants to interact.
- Begin exploring personal associations and experiences with forests.

The process and materials created:



Insights:

Activity 2: Forest, Nature Park, or Adventure Park?

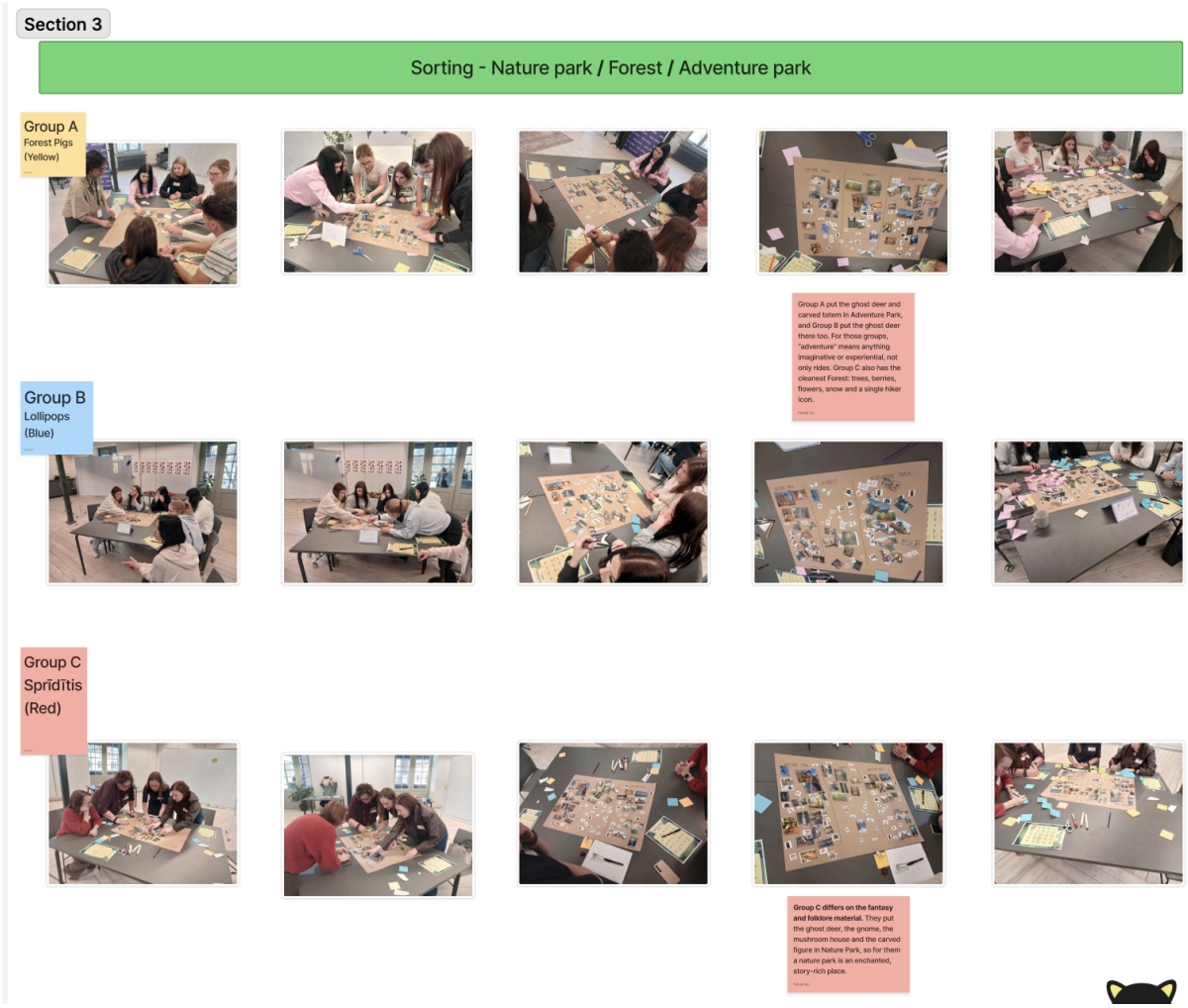
Method: Image sorting

Participants categorized visual elements into three categories: forest, nature park, and adventure park.

Purpose:

- Explore participants' existing mental models of natural spaces.
- Identify how they distinguish different outdoor environments.
- Prepare participants to think about what defines a nature park.

The process and materials created:



Insights: From sorting the picture for the adventure park - “adventure” means anything imaginative or experiential, not only rides. That means that folklore and fairy tales can also be adopted for the adventure park, but will require the “experience” to embrace it. There is no distinct differentiation of “adventure park” and “nature park”, the only difference is the experience that can be lived through.

Activity 3: Yes, And...

Method: Collaborative Storytelling

Participants collaboratively developed stories using the following prompts:

- "Once upon a time in the forest..."
- "We decided to plan an adventure in the forest..."
- "I went to the nature park..."

Each participant built upon the previous contribution, encouraging spontaneity and shared ownership of the story.

Purpose:

- Encourage creativity and collaboration.
- Reduce hesitation about sharing unconventional ideas.
- Reveal associations, emotions, and imagined experiences connected to forests and nature parks

Activity 4: Dream Nature Park (Ideation and Prioritization)

Methods: Brainstorming, affinity mapping, and dot voting

Participants individually generated ideas in response to the question:

"What comes to mind when you think about your dream nature park? Imagine you could create your dream nature park with no rules, no budget, and no limits to your imagination!”

Prompts encouraged consideration of activities, experiences, memories, places, people and seasonal opportunities.

Ideas were organized into categories on group boards. Each participant was allocated three votes to prioritize elements they believed would create the most memorable nature park experience.

Purpose:

- Generate a broad range of ideas.
- Encourage individual contributions before group decisions.
- Identify which experiences participants considered most valuable.

The process and outcomes:

See the picture ->



Insights: The ideas of the adult and teenage groups differ a lot, teenagers tend to have more wild ideas and relate strongly with current trends and pop culture, however you still can see important “themes” emerged - active zones and sports activities, eating zones, lived through experiences, places to take photos, nature had also emerged but it was more like a decoration and not as central part of the experience, question here is how to make nature part of the adventure. For the adult group ideas were more realistic, but themes repeated also. For them nature was a place where those activities took place, not decorations or focal points.

Activity 5: Build Your Dream Nature Park

Method: Collaborative physical prototyping and co-creation

Groups were invited to design their ideal nature park using creative materials like paper, cutouts, legos, markers, string, clay, and other craft supplies.

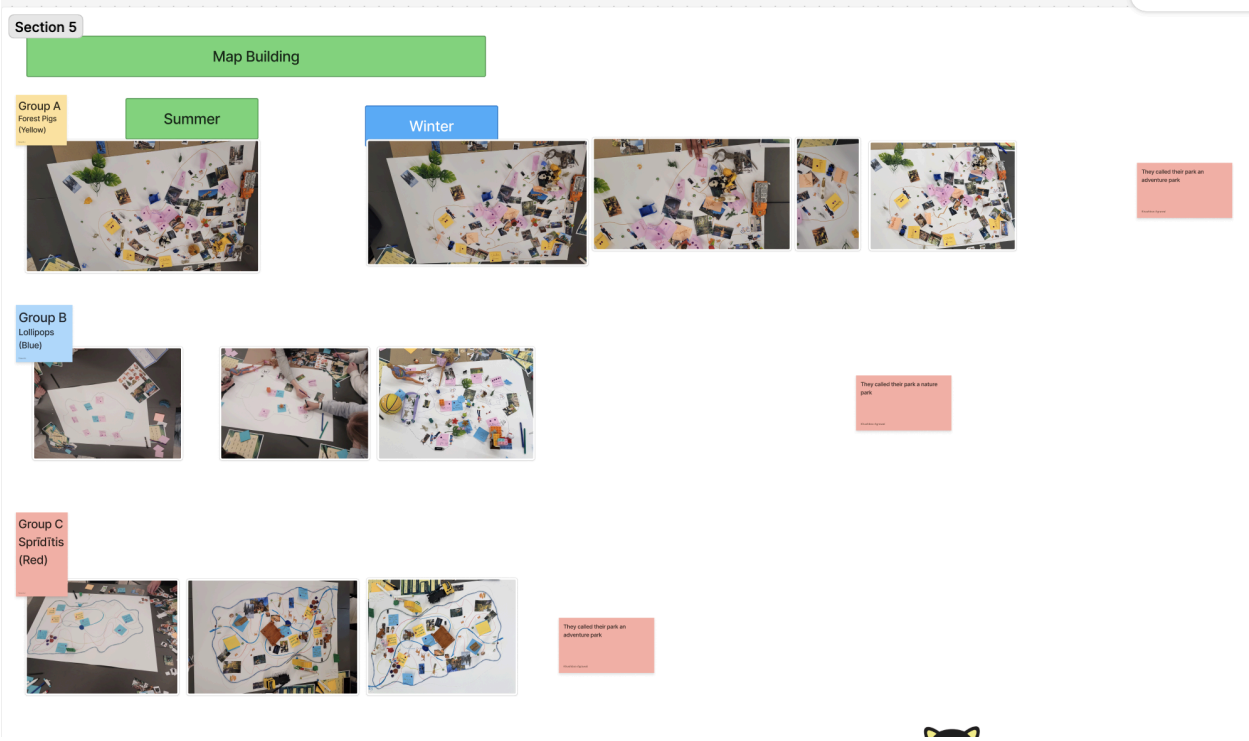
The activity encouraged participants to consider:

- The park's main attractions.
- What makes the park special.
- Admission costs.
- Distance and location.
- Experiences across different seasons, including winter.

Purpose:

- Translate abstract preferences into tangible concepts.
- Observe group decision-making and prioritization.
- Understand which features participants included when given creative freedom.

The process and outcome:



Insights: In this part nature became more like a focal point that connects with the experiences in between, a lot of waterfalls, tree growth, old trees that almost are mythical started to appear, for both of the groups. A lot of emphasis is on the fact that the focal attractions are connected together via experiences and functional zones support each other, unconsciously the flow becomes circular and focuses on a certain flow of people. People were also asked for seasonal adaptation of the park - here a lot of seasonal activities appeared together with festive activities, decorations and mood switching of the whole experience

Activity 6: Park Discussion and Concept Documentation

Methods: Facilitated group discussion, structured questionnaire, and descriptive word association (mad-lib)

Following the park-building activity, facilitators guided each group through a discussion about their completed nature park. This provided an opportunity for participants to reflect on their design decisions, describe their park's features, and communicate what made their concept unique.

Each group was also asked to complete a short questionnaire documenting the key characteristics of their park.

Questionnaire prompts:

1. What is the name of your nature park?
2. How much does it cost to enter your park?

3. What is your park's main attraction?
4. What makes your park special?
5. How far is your park from Kuldīga?

These questions were designed to capture more specific information about participants' priorities, including affordability, attractions, unique experiences, and accessibility.

In addition to the questionnaire, facilitators asked participants to provide descriptive words and details about their parks using a Mad Lib template. Participants supplied words describing their parks and the things visitors could find or experience there.

These responses were collected without initially revealing how they would be used. Facilitators then incorporated the words into fictional visitor reviews, which were read aloud during the final presentations.

Purpose:

- Encourage participants to articulate and reflect on their design choices.
- Document key characteristics of each park in a consistent format.
- Explore participants' priorities regarding cost, attractions, uniqueness, and location.
- Capture descriptive language that reflected how participants imagined their park experience.
- Prepare a playful and personalized conclusion to the workshop through Mad Lib reviews.

Insights: 2 out of 3 groups mentioned the “free” aspect of the park, which could be translated into the feeling of getting something in return together with buying a ticket. Maybe a free drink, a seasonal gift or other things.

Activity 7: Park Presentations and Mad Lib Reviews

Methods: Storytelling, group presentations, and playful reflection

Each group presented its park concept to the other participants.

As a humorous conclusion, facilitators read fictional Mad Lib-style visitor reviews incorporating words that participants had previously provided to describe their parks.

Purpose:

- Allow participants to communicate the intended experience of their parks.
- Celebrate the groups' creations.
- Reinforce engagement through humor.
- Conclude the activity on a positive and memorable note.

Activity 8: Closing Reflection

Method: Thermometer activity

A short closing exercise using playful preference questions and an energy check to gather immediate reactions.

Purpose:

- Conclude the workshop.
- Gauge participants' energy and engagement.
- End with a low-pressure reflective activity.

3. Outputs and Outcomes

3.1 Workshop Outputs

The workshop produced several forms of qualitative material for further qualitative analysis. These can help identify recurring themes relevant to the LVM project.

- Individual ideas about ideal nature park experiences.
- Group sorting and prioritization exercises.
- Physical nature park concepts.
- Group presentations explaining the park designs.
- Mad Lib reviews incorporating participants' descriptive words.

3.2 Key Findings and Insights

Finding 1: Emphasis on activities and experiences that drive people to the park

Across the designed parks, participants incorporated numerous activities, including skiing, skating, mountain climbing, volleyball, petting cats, and even couples therapy.

These ideas varied considerably but shared a common characteristic: participants imagined parks as places where visitors could *actively* do something or go to the park for an experience that is worth the time and money spent on getting there.

Opportunity: Explore how nature-based activities, social recreation, and interactive experiences could make parks more attractive to visitors without compromising their natural character. The availability of activities and opportunities for entertainment can be explored.

Finding 2: Park as a social experience

Participants imagined visiting their parks with either friends or family, not visiting on their own. This suggests that the people accompanying visitors may be an important part of the experience. They also wanted opportunities to document their experiences, for example the concept of photo booths was brought up several times.

Opportunity: Investigate how visitor needs differ between peer groups and families, and whether existing park experiences adequately support both. The activities mentioned by the groups are more exciting that seems to be missing in the park currently.

Finding 3: Free access was a recurring priority

Teenager groups strongly emphasized that their parks should be free to visit. Some went further, imagining parks that would pay visitors to attend.

Opportunity: Explore the role of affordability and perceived value in young people's decisions to visit nature parks. How can the park have a lower cost of entry and provide stairstep pricing for other experiences?

Finding 4: Animals appeared in every park concept

All groups incorporated some form of animal-related feature. Examples included opportunities to interact with animals, such as petting cats, having a zoo, observing wild animals.

Opportunity: Explore interest in wildlife-related experiences, such as animal observation, educational trails, or other opportunities to engage with local biodiversity.

Miscellaneous Finding: Connection to folklore between Teenager and Adults

In the sorting exercise, the teenager groups sorted fairytale and folklore images into adventure parks while the adults sorted them into nature parks. This shows the teenagers do not connect magical/mythical elements with the wild nature of the forests rather see them as theme

attractions used at amusement parks.

4. Impact on the Project Stage and Suggested Next Steps

4.1 Contribution to the Project

The workshop contributed to the exploratory stage of the project by generating initial insights into how local young people imagine and value nature park experiences.

It helped identify potential visitor motivations and highlighted differences between the perspectives of younger participants and nature park professionals.

The results can inform the development of more focused research questions and provide inspiration for future experience concepts.

Rather than treating the park designs as direct recommendations for implementation, the team can use them to identify the underlying needs and motivations expressed by participants.

For example, a suggestion to include volleyball may indicate a desire for active recreation and social interaction, while animal-related attractions may point toward curiosity, engagement, and memorable encounters with nature.

4.2 Suggested Next Steps

One thing that stands out is that people are looking for a reason to visit. The park currently lacks the excitement that drives visitors to the park. We want to explore how to incorporate magic and adventure in the park, which are the themes that came up often from the participants during our workshop. We are leading with problem areas around excitement and adventure within the park, giving visitors a reason to want to return and leaving them with a memorable experience.

Our next steps include elaborating further on this idea of where do locals go for excitement and looking at the current journey inside the park to spot the levels of excitement in the journey and identifying gaps.

5. Conclusion & Next Steps

The *Into the Woods* workshop successfully engaged local teenagers and adults in a collaborative exploration of nature park experiences.

One thing that stands out is that people are looking for a reason to visit. The park currently lacks the excitement that drives visitors to the park. We want to explore how to incorporate magic and adventure in the park, which are the themes that came up often from the participants during our

workshop. We are leading with problem areas around excitement and adventure within the park, giving visitors a reason to want to return and leaving them with a memorable experience.

Our next steps include elaborating and investigating further on this idea of where do locals go for excitement and looking at the current journey inside the park to spot the levels of excitement in the journey and identifying gaps and intervening within the current infrastructure.